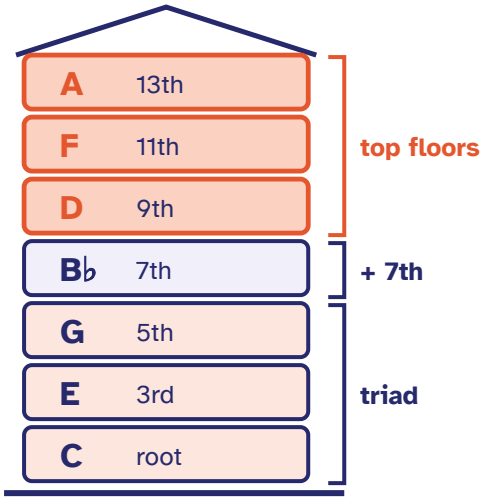
PART IV · CHORDS · 7

The tower: 9, 11, 13

Why stop at the 7th? Keep stacking 3rds and the cake grows three more layers: the 9th, the 11th and the 13th. At the top you have used **all seven letters, A to G**.

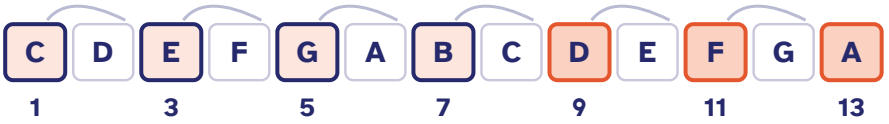
THE SECRET

Keep skipping letters above the 7th: 9, 11, 13 are 2, 4, 6 an octave up.



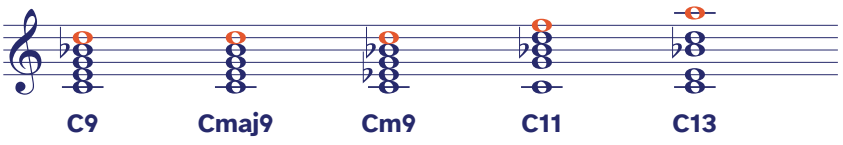
1. Build the seventh chord: **C E G B♭** (C7).
2. Keep skipping one letter: **D**, **F**, **A**. Those layers are the **9th, 11th and 13th**.
3. Take 7 away to find the letter: 9 → 2nd (D), 11 → 4th (F), 13 → 6th (A). Same letters, an octave up.

Skip a letter, all the way up



Start on C and take every other letter: C E G B D F A (letters only: in C7 the B is B♭). After the 13th comes C again: the tower is full.

Five tall chords on C

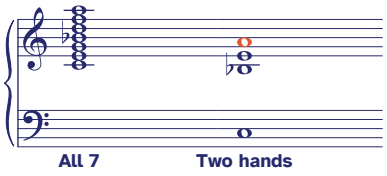


The red note is the top layer that gives each chord its name. C11 and C13 leave some notes out: see p. 106.

CHORD	BUILT AS	NOTES	SOUNDS	HEARD IN
C9	C7 + 9th	C E G B♭ **D**	soulful	funk, soul
Cmaj9	Cmaj7 + 9th	C E G B **D**	dreamy	film, ballads
Cm9	Cm7 + 9th	C E♭ G B♭ **D**	smooth	neo-soul, R&B
C11	C9 + 11th, no 3rd	C G B♭ D **F**	airy	gospel, pop
C13	C7 + 13th	C E B♭ (D) **A**	rich	jazz, blues endings

PART IV · CHORDS · 7 · CONTINUED

Too many notes? Leave some out



All seven notes sound muddy. Two hands play C13 with four: C in the left hand, B♭ E A in the right.

Ten fingers, seven layers: you choose. **Keep** the 3rd and the 7th (they say what kind of chord it is) and the red top note (its colour). **Leave out** the 5th first. The right hand can drop the root too, when the left hand or a bass player plays it.

With a major 3rd, the 11th (F) rubs against E. So C13 leaves out the F. C11 does the opposite: it keeps the F and leaves out the E.

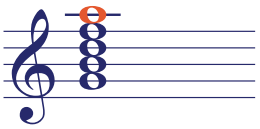
6 or 13? add9 or 9?

SAME TOP NOTE	WITHOUT THE 7TH	WITH THE 7TH (B♭)
A on C	**C6**: C E G A	**C13**: C E B♭ A
D on C	**Cadd9**: C E G D	**C9**: C E G B♭ D

Look for the 7th. No 7th: a colour chord (p. 102). A 7th: a tower chord.

EXAMPLE 1

Name this tall chord: G B D F A



G B D F A

?

1. **Find the root:** each note skips one letter, so the bottom note is the root.
2. **The first four layers:** count the keys between. Which seventh?
3. **The red top layer:** which number is it above G?

G7 (3 + 2 + 2) with A, the 9th, on top: **G9**.

GAME

Which floor?

1 — the 9th of C

2 — the 11th of C

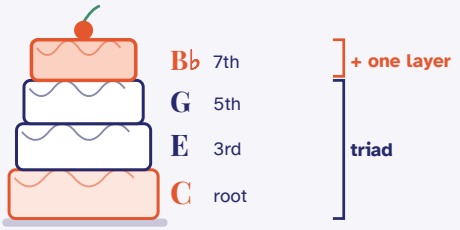
3 — the 13th of C

Build C7 (C E G B♭), then keep skipping one letter above the B♭.

Answer: 1 D · 2 F · 3 A.

PART IV · CHORDS · 7 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

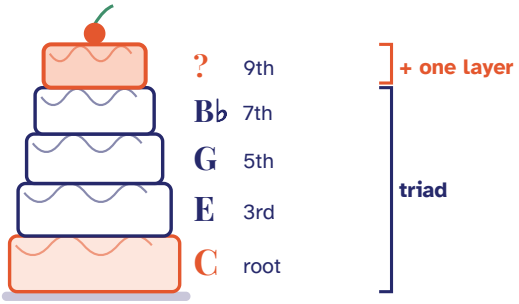


Play C7, then add one more.

Left hand C E G, right hand B♭, then add the next letter but one above it. You just built a tall chord.

EXAMPLE 2

Build C9



1. **Build C7:** C E G B♭.
2. **Skip one more letter** above B♭: which letter?
3. **Five notes:** share them between the hands if you need to.

C9: C E G B♭ **D**, one layer above the 7th.

HOW TO

Build any tall chord

1. **Start on the root** and skip one letter each time: 1 3 5 7 9 11 13.
2. **Stop** at the number in the name.
3. **Leave out** the 5th first; in a 13th chord, the 11th too, when it is too many notes for your hands.

THINK OF IT You don't need every layer. Keep the 3rd and the 7th, which say what kind of chord it is, and the top layer, which gives it its colour.

TRAP

- × Hunting far up for the 9th: it is just the 2nd, an octave higher (D on C).
- × Calling C13 a C6: the 13th chord has the 7th (B♭) as well.
- × Playing F and E together in C13 or C11: they clash. C13 drops the F; C11 drops the E.

SEE ALSO

Seventh chords p. 99 · Colour chords p. 102

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 7 · Online: Library › Chords